

Diem's other problems were mounting. The Strategic Hamlets Program was proving a failure and the Buddhists called for political reform. Diem's American allies were increasingly concerned.

Diem's generals were also disaffected. On August 23, just two days after Nhu's security police had raided Buddhist temples in Saigon and Hue, ARVN Chief of Staff Tran Van Don told Lucien Conein, a veteran CIA officer operating under cover, that a coup d'état was being planned. The generals would not act without US approval.

Opinion in the White House was divided, but on August 26, Kennedy acted. The new US ambassador in Saigon, Henry Cabot Lodge, was authorized to inform the generals that, while the US would not actively help them to mount their coup, it would support a new government, once formed.